Portfolio 1 Reflection Report

Did you find the assignment brief clear?

Yes, mostly. The main stuff was clear enough – three project cards, links to live sites and GitHub, CV and cover letter as downloadable files, small improvements on each project, update the READMEs, plus this reflection and a short video.

I thought the reflection was only supposed to be about the three projects and the fixes I made. Then I went back and re-read the deliverables section properly and realised I also had to write about how I handled building the portfolio itself. Should've checked that earlier.

Teacher let me use TING (Project Exam 1) instead of the Cross Course Project, which was good because my JS1 project was already Rainy Days. So I ended up with three different sites instead of two that looked kind of similar.

Planning and design

Felt like this deadline was tighter than usual and with some personal stuff happening this week I decided not to over complicate the portfolio. Looked at a few portfolios from other developers to gain inspiration, then sketched a rough layout in windows paint and brought it to life.

Thought about doing a 3D carousel for the projects but dropped it because I felt it's better to just show all three cards at once so people can see everything immediately. Settled on a normal hover effect instead.

Final layout is pretty basic: intro, tools I'm comfortable with, some of the tech we've only touched on in class, the three project cards, About section, and contact. Kept the "confident with" tools separate from the "only seen it in class" stuff on purpose. I wanted to show my experience honestly without making all technologies look like core skills.

Buttons looked too generic at first so I changed them to a more boxy style with borders and a bit of shadow. For the About section I made an illustrated avatar from a photo of myself (OpenAI helped with that one).

How did you manage the project?

One file at a time. Got the HTML structure solid first before touching CSS too much. Typed with live server open and tested as I went.

Once the portfolio itself was working I did the three project improvements one after the other and used teacher feedback where I had it. For the museum site there wasn't any formal feedback so I just went through the code myself looking for something small but useful to fix since deadline was nearing.

I then wrote the README.md for the 3 projects with help from the template provided in module 1.2.

What worked well?

Keeping it simple worked. The project cards are easy to find and each one has a screenshot, short description, and the links.

Used Flexbox, Grid and media queries. Put the SVG icons in as normal image files instead of pulling in some big icon library.

Working from actual teacher feedback was better than just looking for something to change.

Problems and solutions

Biggest issue was deciding how much to do before time ran out. I kept thinking of extra features but forced myself to stick to presenting the projects properly and making small clean fixes.

Caught a few dumb mistakes while checking the code – wrong class names, a grid container that closed too early, missing parameter in a function. Small stuff but it breaks things.

TING – Project Exam 1

Live site: https://tommyaarstein.github.io/ProjectExam1-FED/

Online store built with HTML, CSS and vanilla JS. Learned a lot about fetching from APIs, auth, and handling the cart state.

Improvement: Teacher said the cart validation wasn't good enough. Original code only checked if localStorage had an array. Didn't check if the items inside actually had proper IDs and quantities.

Fix: Added checks so every entry must be an object with a non-empty string ID and a positive safe integer quantity. Invalid entries are filtered out while valid ones are kept. I also moved the localStorage read inside the existing try/catch block so storage access errors are handled too.

Commit: https://github.com/tommyaarstein/ProjectExam1-FED/commit/960e593f46cee7b9c570965c7eda1f909539e8fa

Rainy Days – JavaScript 1

Live site: https://tommyaarstein.github.io/FED1-JS1-CA/

Project was about fetching products from an API, showing them, and making the cart work.

Improvement: Teacher pointed out that the price formatting and the cart badge update were repeated in several different files.

Fix: Moved both into a utils.js file. Now everything just calls formatPrice() and updateCartBadge(). Much cleaner. If I need to change how prices look later I only have to do it in one place.

Commit: https://github.com/tommyaarstein/FED1-JS1-CA/commit/17e4afb06eb2f99689f868c06e618cd9250d26e7

Tromsø Community Science Museum – Semester Project 1

Live site: https://tommyaarstein.github.io/community-science-museum/

Multi-page museum site, pure HTML and CSS. Good practice for responsive layouts and navigation.

Improvement: No teacher feedback on this one so I looked through it myself. The mobile menu used a hidden checkbox for the toggle. It could get keyboard focus but the actual menu icon never showed a focus outline when you tabbed to it.

Fix: Added a visible outline on the label when the checkbox is focused, and hid the checkbox completely on desktop where the normal nav is already showing. Small CSS change but it fixed the accessibility issue on all five pages.

Commit: https://github.com/tommyaarstein/community-science-museum/commit/1abb2188ccd04c4548236c0f5589f81c9f58a4bb

Use of AI and building on existing skills

Used ChatGPT and Codex for design ideas, checking code snippets, explaining stuff I didn't get, and helping write some of the documentation. Still wrote all the actual code myself and asked follow-up questions when the suggestions weren't clear. Avatar was AI-generated too.

Knowing the basics (loops, arrays, functions, HTML, CSS) was enough to get through the updates.

What would I do differently next time?

Make one proper checklist at the start that covers everything – portfolio, the three fixes, documentation, final files – instead of juggling it as I went.

Leave more time at the end just for testing and writing the documentation. Doing small checks while you work is fine but leaving the final testing until the last day is stressful and something I want to avoid next time.

And hopefully I will not have a busy schedule when the next course assignment comes.